Do It Yourself:

an Earnest Appeal

Adapted from Hattiesburg Alternative zine 5

Spring 2026

hattiesburg-alt.neocities.org

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If you're familiar with the DIY community or have been going out to punk or DIY events, I hope you've been delighted to see physical media, like cassettes, band shirts, zines, flyers, books, crafts, buttons, and stickers for sale or being freely distributed. Someone new to the scene may be wondering why there is this emphasis on physical media when streaming services like spotify and amazon exist and simplify sources of media consumption.

Every piece of physical media you own reflects an independent decision and choice you made to approach someone, interact with them, and gain something from them. At shows, this will be directly from the artists and creators. Owning physical media in this way is more than an aesthetic choice, it signifies you've made a connection with the original source of the media.

"I like to collect all kinds of physical media. As long as I have something to play it on, then I'll collect it. I feel like, depending on what it's recorded on, everything has such a distinct and interesting sound.

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Cassettes sound different than vinyl records and CDs sound different than vinyl records, obviously, but everything kind of has a charm to it, you know?" -Lauren Stamps

Do it yourself. (DIY.)

These choices to retain physical media after they have been reframed as outdated or obsolete go beyond personal preference, but culminate as a collective of individual commitments to the standards of DIY.

What's DIY?

DIY stands for "do it yourself," and it means exactly that. In our scene, this term is applied to nearly every aspect of the arts and its consumption from creation to recording and publishing, events and shows, and distribution. It also expands into many

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other aspects of existence such as home improvement, auto and mechanical repairs, gardening, crafting, and similar areas. DIY in every application remains a counter-cultural movement, especially as manufacturers, streaming services, and social media platforms encourage consumer dependence on them and make it more difficult to do things yourself.

What binds DIY?

So, if DIY develops the independence of the individuals who practice it, what connects everyone involved and what makes these concepts the foundation for an artistic movement?

Mutual Aid.

Beyond shared interests and longing for community and friendships, Mutual Aid is a truly binding concept and action. Mutual Aid is the simple act of

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When I see hands grabbing, yanking, and snatching peaceful people from the street, cars, and homes, I think of hands that could be cradling their children, embracing their lovers, growing food, or building homes. I think of the hands of the contributors of this zine, whose hands create art and write poetry and music.

helping people how you can with the means at your disposal. It is not earned or transactional and it depends on the social, cooperative, and benign nature of helpful people. It is the open sharing of information, skills, resources, and effort. This is nothing new and is hopefully something that you have already participated in. It can look like donating food or to charity, helping a friend move, or assisting each other in artistic measures. If you ever did something for someone else, just to see them benefit, where it had no direct reward to yourself, you have already participated in Mutual Aid.

Ethos of DIY.

An ethos, in this context, is a set of core beliefs that guide the culture and behaviors of everyone involved in the DIY community. In DIY, some of these core beliefs are:

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An ethos, in this context, is a set of core beliefs that guide the culture and behaviors of everyone involved in the DIY community. In DIY, some of these core beliefs are:

- Anti-racism and anti-authoritarianism – DIY actively counters the racism and fascism that curses our country and society.
- Non-commercial – DIY should be either free or be raising funds for a good cause. The pursuit of profit hampers accessibility and influences content for popular consumption.
- Informational – DIY should be practical and specialized to assist with self-reliance and to counter misinformation.
- Community-centric – DIY forms bonds with like-minded individuals and contributes toward mutual aid to all those in need. It encourages cooperation beyond social norms.

"One of the most important parts of being involved in DIY is the community. I never felt like I belonged anywhere before I found punk. There's a sense of solidarity with everyone involved, and you end up making friends that live across the country from you. Hell, even overseas sometimes. Whether they're on

The duty to protect the vulnerable among us is sacred. It is demanded, and its void will be felt well beyond the immediate terror and into future generations. It is a centrist and non-radical position to demand the abolition of institutions which kill us and terrorize us. It is a centrist and moderate position to demand the removal of tyrannical public servants. It's a centrist and self-preserving position to demand that life, liberty, and humanity be respected above law and order.

Sometimes the truth is dark and scary. Sometimes the people and systems we trust betray us. Sometimes things don't get better unless we directly confront the injustices in front of us. A structure built on faulty foundations does not correct itself. We must directly and purposefully correct foundational issues. Rotten trees do not bear good fruit, and corrupt and immoral politicians fail their citizens.

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Moreover, a scene and a community must stand for something. What that is, is up to us. We can stand for compassion, anti-racism, and anti-authoritarianism or we can stand for empty pride, revisionist history, America-first, and scorn. We can have freedom, liberty, justice, and opportunity, or we can have limits over our bodies, identities, and education. We can have migrants flourish in this country or we can

have squads of roaming masked federal agents, killing and kidnapping in our streets and endless wars.

"Everything has upset me again this morning. It is terrible outside. Families are torn apart, the men, women, and children all being separated. Children come home from school to find that their parents have disappeared. Women return from shopping to find their homes shut up and their families gone." - Anne Frank, January 13th, 1943.

tour coming through Hattiesburg, or I'm on tour going through their city, I'm always meeting new really cool people or seeing friends I don't see often. As somebody who grew up as the "weird kid" and felt out of place, I've finally found somewhere that really gives me a sense of belonging."
-Patrick Smith

Acknowledging Risk

Living and speaking out for the values of DIY is not always safe and the risks surrounding this vary from person to person and from time to location. Despite these ideals being morally and ethically justified as well as the expression of them being constitutionally protected, there are often consequences to doing so. Each individual must decide for themselves how much risk they are willing to take, but even if you are not willing to take risk in a specific situation, there is still always something you can do to support those who do.

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“I think it's important to advocate as a scene because there's people within the scene that, you know, there's vulnerable communities within your scene like queer people, Black people, people that might be without a home, or just without a stable living place. So, I think it's important to advocate for those people because oftentimes they can't advocate for themselves because of their lack of resources.”
-Nyomi

Accessibility

is another important principle of DIY that needs to be considered in all aspects of DIY culture and activity. Streaming services and popular social media are very easy, affordable, and simple to use. However, when it is feasible, a return to physical media and downloadable digital media is better for both the fan and the artist and is a more ethical way to consume under capitalism. It’s also less addictive, less intrusive of your data, and allows you more

Staying on the grind and playing by the rules of capitalism is exhausting, brutal, and isolating. The strong do not win, only those willing to sacrifice their passions and futures for those who in turn sacrifice their humanity and the bodies of those who work for them. The community is struggling. Joy is scarce during an ethnic cleansing. Rest and opportunity are scarce under a fascist regime.

Yet we cannot give ground to our fears. We cannot burn out or self-isolate. We need to make a point to spend effort forming community because of the important networks it creates and how it benefits our mental health. These networks save lives and preserve liberty, and with these networks, we can share information, organize, support each other through mutual aid, and create spaces that are safe for our authentic existence.

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We have inherited a country that was created by domination and subjugation. One that was built on stolen land during the genocide of the native people of the First Nations of America and on the cruel, forced labor of enslaved African people. Far too many citizens of the U.S. fear the loss of this dominance, politically, culturally, and literally. This fear and other weaknesses, such as the expectation to assimilate, racism, rape culture, and other methods of dehumanization, are easily exploited to separate and control us. We must systemically and as a community look inward, face these fears and prejudices, and move past them to find compassion, empathy, truth, memory, and honor. Then, we must act on what we find.

Our struggles are not individualistic. We should not be measuring our country's success by the stock market, the GDP, or the glamor of our CEOs and celebrities. We should be measuring our success by the way the poorest and most vulnerable of us live, and how readily and fully their freedoms are protected.

intention in your choices of what you want to consume. It's your choice, and it can be gradual.

But isn't physical media wasteful and bad for the environment?

In terms of physical waste, only if you dispose of your physical media. It does require energy and some resources to produce something physical, but so do the servers that host streaming platforms, "cloud" storage, and social media platforms. Besides, billionaires and corporations should not have a monopoly on creating waste and pollution, especially when ours is drastically smaller than theirs.

Ok well where should I get my media then?

Bandcamp.com for music. There's a lot of music there that you can download for free or "name your

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price," and if you can't afford to purchase music, don't feel bad about listing "$0." If they weren't ok with free downloads, they would have listed a price! You can always go back and pay something when you're in a better financial situation.

Go to a show! You can check out all the coolest local, DIY shows and upload your own flyer by visiting hatttiesburg.askapunk.net. It's even run and managed by local punks. At shows, you can buy physical media directly from bands and artists!

Don't forget about the library! There's more than books, also movies and music as well. The library is a social service that communities desperately need and just getting a card and using it supports them! There's also thrift stores, estate/yard sales, facebook marketplace, and thriftbooks.com to name a few.

Make it yourself! If you want to be in a community with more bands, or zines, or art, you can start with your own work! When it comes to art, music, and creative writing, don't let anyone tell you (even yourself) that you're not good or ready yet.

something we can do to protect our freedoms while our rights are routinely violated, and with every new injustice that American society accepts, we all lose a bit of our freedom. It's something we can do to push back against people who will never face the fears that we do. Who will never fear the loss of their home, of their family, of security, or dignity, or food, water, or air. Who sit upon endless wealth, but still hunger and endlessly consume innocence and vulnerability. Because to them, to be powerful is to be dominant, and it is our freedom that threatens their control.

In past issues, I have spoken about the beauty and joy of developing your true self and of the simple freedoms we deserve. Now, we must go further to protect and defend the beauty and joy in our communities and the people who complete them. At the same time, we must realize we are not more deserving of life and liberty than the people of Iran, Cuba, Palestine, and Sudan, who are suffering and dying, and migrants, who come to us seeking refuge but receive oppression.

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AI crawls across the internet, eating our art, music, personal data, but it cannot replicate the nuance and undertones that make our art good and impactful. It cannot even create on its own, only regurgitating conglomerated bits of our humanity back to us. Remember, it was made by the same groups of people who swore by NFTs and bitcoin.

Beyond the environmental damage AI causes, the massive, city scale amounts of water its centers use, the pollution its gas generators create, and the absurd energy requirements, its art is horrible, its music sucks, and its writing is ass. There is no reason to use it as individuals, and it slowly strips us of our ability to fully function.

Why is DIY important?

DIY is an ethos, practice, and community that reclaims control of our media, information, and nodes of communication. Participating in DIY is

Everything comes with practice, and part of practice is the act of creation. Get out the capitalist mindset that the end goal of the arts is a product but rather simply something that humanity does as a byproduct of our nature.

There's also fediverse.party and mastodon for social media, proton.me for email, signal for messaging, firefox for internet browsers, duckduckgo for search engines, and AJ+ and NPR for news.

How about a DIY server?

With some experience in coding and computer literacy, it's possible to take an old computer and transform it into a server that can host social media platforms, websites, cloud storage, programs, and apps. A DIY server will give us a way to share information, data, resources, zines, and media between ourselves and other interested people in the DIY community.

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Artificial Intelligence

is something that's used everyday now by a lot of us. Originally imagined for its uses in data analysis and pattern recognition in the applied sciences, AI has quickly been targeted towards everyday use and in the office workspace.

"Large language models are primarily marketed towards your boss, not because they'll actually save your boss money or time. They really just want your boss to replace you with AI and if they can sell your boss on that, it doesn't matter if it actually works or not, your boss will always take the automated solution over the human because you don't need to pay a large language model PTO or give them healthcare benefits." -Evelyn Evans

It's frustrating and somewhat insulting to be directed by an AI generated email, policy change, or notice at a workplace by poorly crafted wording by a misinformed machine. Worse still, AI is used for basic correspondence between individuals, where it's essentially communicating with itself. It's such a truly bizarre instance of false productivity. Using AI does not give us more free time or make our jobs easier, it just creates more emails and bad essays and reports.

Ultimately, it's the loss of imagination and full participation in the arts that worries me the most. AI provides answers, simplification, and affirmation to any prompt we give it and is fundamentally opposed to everything we are as artists and members of the DIY community.

"When the infinite possibilities of life have been reduced to an array of options coded in ones and zeros, there will be no more friction between the system we inhabit and the lives we can imagine—not

because we will have achieved total freedom, but because we will have perfected its opposite. Freedom doesn't mean choosing between options, but formulating the questions." -*To Change Everything: An Anarchist Appeal*

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